The choice to sail away

When I tell people that I lived on a sailboat and that I've sailed over 13,000 miles, they probably have various images in their heads of what that looked like and how I ended up there. Maybe I sailed around the world to visit numerous stunning and remote islands for the beauty and adventure, but in reality, my reasoning was very different.

To start from the beginning, my dad bought our sailboat when I was two years old. We lived on it together,
aside from when I would spend time with my mom, who had split custody of me after their divorce. The boat was a 34-foot monohull, and it had old brown sails and wooden decks that I loved to lie on. My dad was a diesel mechanic and marine electrician in our marina, which was more in demand than one might think. Living in Marina Del Rey, the largest man-made marina in North America, made plenty of work.

When I got a bit older, most days we would both work, spending most of the day in a cramped engine locker doing maintenance on a motor that hadn't been run in 10 years or a bilge compartment with some mysterious salty leak. But one day, on the 4th of July, I got a phone call from a number I did not recognize while watching the fireworks. A woman had called me to tell me my mom had been found in her home that night and that she'd passed away a few days prior. I couldn't tell you exactly what I did when I heard the woman give me the news. I don't remember; I don't think I even answered her until she called my name at least five or six times.

After that, nothing felt the same; neither of us had much patience or optimism for anything. A few months later, my dad asked me if I was open to doing something different. I thought he meant a new city, a new profession, or a new work schedule- maybe even taking a week or two off, so I said yes. Little did I know my dad had far different ideas. I knew he was planning something, but I didn't know what, and out of all the possibilities that I had considered, him telling me he had quit his job and that we were leaving the USA was not one of them. I laughed, thinking he was pulling my leg, but the following morning, when I tossed the dock lines off the bow, I was proven wrong. Looking at my dad behind the wheel, I thought he had finally snapped and gone off the deep end.

Once out of the marina, I asked where we were going, and he pointed at a flat blue horizon and said, "That way." Yeah, I was convinced he'd lost it. But, I didn't mind, sailing away from all my problems didn't sound so bad, so I nodded and off we went. The furthest i had ever sailed was from the California coast to the Catalina Islands, which took about 7 hours, I wasnt sure what to think when I sat on the bow that night, watching the dark water arc away from the nose of our small boat as we sailed, the boat felt much smaller with an endless depth beneath that I couldnt see, and I felt even smaller with the vast emptiness as far as I could see, I couldnt understand why I was scared of not being able to see anything, and of seeing nothing, as if they were different from one another.

The date we left was October 7th, 2020. First, we sailed one night to Catalina from the Channel Islands, which was my last time in American waters for the next five years. After that, I enrolled in an online school and we sailed to Mexico.

I was ill-experienced to be half responsible for both our lives and the well being of the vessel but thats how I saw it each time I was on night watch alone, reminded how small I was while staring out at something to dark to focus on, maybe it was the lack of moonlight on the water, or maybe the fact I didnt know where we were actually going. But many nights spent with myself behind the wheel as the season grew colder and the wind turned to come from the north. I grew more confident when looking out ahead of the boat, moonlight or not, I wasn't scared of it anymore, me being small or not. As time went on and miles got scratched on the chart, I became confident in my abilities.

I felt once I had grown to know myself out there, and grown to trust myself, only then did the strength to face what had happened on fourth of July, a full year had passed and i was brought back to that night in the park when the colors filled the sky again, I assured myself I was stronger now, and brave enough to face it. Looking up at the bright fireworks, all my assurance was wrong; I was no braver, and no bigger than before. I felt no older than 13, no bigger than a small boat in the middle of nowhere, and not strong enough to keep the tears from reaching my cheeks.

I realized I couldn't outrun it. And even though I was afraid, I had to face it. And that was because I chose to sail thousands of miles from home, through the unknown, and without her there, I was capable of facing anything that scared me, painful or not. I knew I could trust myself now. I believe if we hadn't left, and I hadn't been forced to grow into myself in that way, I would not have gained the courage to face my fears, not just in that instance but for all the challenges I’ll face throughout my lifetime.